

This week is **פרשת פרה** and also **פרשת צו**. We are learning today as a **זכות** for **בית ישראל**, particularly the members of the IDF, whose lives are put on the line and in harm's way as they strive to help **כלל ישראל** and rid us of our enemies. We are also celebrating the **אופרוך** of the newest member of our family, the honorable R' Chaim Mandel. We embrace and welcome him with open arms into our ever-growing and ever-improving family. Additionally, the **ארצייתי** of my **ע"ה** **בת מרדכי צבי** is approaching in the next week or two, and **בשורת השם**, this learning should be an **עליה** for her **נשמה**.

פרשת ויקרא, which continues to discuss more details of the קרבנות begun in פרשת ויקרא, is connected to פרשת צור, which deals with the אדומה. Although the אדומה is not a קרבן, many of its הלכות are similar to those of the קרבנות. פרשת ויקרא, which we read at the end of our regular leining, has a fascinating רש"י on the words אֲדָמָה. Rabbi Oelbaum, in his שיעור pointed out this רש"י, I'll read it to you from פרשת ויקרא - אַמְשֵׁל לְבֹן שִׁפְחָהּ שְׂטוֹנָה פְּלִטוֹן שֶׁל מֶלֶךְ - A servant woman brought her baby to the king's palace and the baby made a mess; אָמְרוּ תָבֵא אִמּוֹ וְתִקְנָנָה הַצֹּואָה - Let his mother come and clean up the mess; כֹּה תָבֵא פָּרָה - so too the אדומה comes to be מכפר the חטא of the עגל, the greatest חטא in history, which we had in תשא just a few weeks ago.

Rabbi Oelbaum cited the טעם ודעת from R' Moshe Sternbuch, who quoted Rav Itzele Peterburger. What is the connection between the פרה אדומה and the משל that רש"י brings about the baby who soils the king's palace, requiring his mother to come clean it up? Another item which Rabbi Oelbaum alluded to is the unpleasant experience of a child's dirty diaper. What purpose could there possibly be for such an occurrence?

He brings a beautiful explanation, based on פסוק א' (ד'ד') ישעיהו in פסוק א' (ד'ד') ישעיהו. What does this mean? When a baby soils himself, most people are repulsed. They step away, wrinkle their noses, and say, “Ugh, that stinks! Take him away!” The entire world finds the situation disgusting and unpleasant. But there is one person who rushes to take care of the baby, who embraces the responsibility with love and care - his mother. The mother does not recoil; instead, she runs to clean him up, comfort him, and make him feel better. She does this out of pure love, knowing that her care will help him. This, says the נביא, is our relationship with ה' הקדוש ברוך הוא. The חטא העגל was a horrifying עבירה - an act of spiritual defilement committed right there at סיני הר סיני. Who could possibly cleanse such a stain? Only ה' הקדוש ברוך הוא Himself. And how does He do it? Through the פרה אדומה. Just as a mother lovingly cleans her child despite the mess, ה' הקדוש ברוך הוא, in His infinite love for כלל ישראל, provides us with the means to cleanse ourselves. The פרה אדומה represents this divine compassion and the constant opportunity for כפרה, no matter how severe the חטא.

This concept also teaches us a profound lesson about the great endeavor known as family. We live in a time when family values are under attack from all directions, across all societies and cultures. The world seeks to undermine the very foundation of the family unit. But we in כלל ישראל cherish and revere the concept of family. We uphold it as one of the greatest gifts that הקדוש ברוך הוא has given us. We recognize how wrong the world is and how right הקדוש ברוך הוא is in granting us the privilege of building families, raising children, and experiencing true נחת. It is in this spirit of joy and gratitude that we welcome the newest member of our family. We are thrilled to embrace him and look forward to his vibrant role in our ever-growing family.

Im Yirtzeh Hashem, may our family continue to grow both in **כמות** and **איכות**, ever stronger in our **עבודת** **השם** and our dedication to **כלל ישראל**.

